How to Order Classic Chinese Dishes from an Unfamiliar Menu

— Decode the Style & Cooking Method

[Team Members]

[TA]

宫保鸡丁 Kung Pao Chicken

鱼香肉丝 Fish-Fragrant Shredded Pork

麻婆豆腐 Mapo Tofu

回锅肉 Twice-cooked Pork

About This Learning Experience

Domain: Food Literacy / Chinese Culinary Vocabulary

Topic: Decoding Chinese restaurant menu descriptions

Expert: Shurong Zhang

Target User: Non-Chinese diners seeking culinary confidence

By the end of this 10-minute prototype, you will be able to:

Recognize Chinese cooking methods and predict texture

Read flavor & style words to anticipate taste and spice level

Decode any unfamiliar Chinese dish name with confidence

Covers 2 lessons + 1 quiz (interleaved)

Click here to continue

Your Menu Decoding Journey

Here's what you'll learn today — let's get started!

Stage 1: Methods — Stage 2: Flavor — Quiz — Final Reveal

Stage 1 — Cooking Methods = Texture

Learn how Chinese cooking techniques predict what your food will look and taste like.

Stage 2 — Flavor & Style Words = Taste Preview

Decode regional styles and flavor signals hidden in dish names.

Quiz — Progressive Decoding + Scenario

Test your skills with real Chinese dish names and real-world ordering scenarios.

Final Reveal — Decode the Mystery Dish

Put it all together on the dish from the opening slide to see the final transformation.

All stages upcoming — let's begin!

The Hook: "Fish-Fragrant Shredded Pork"

Yu-Xiang Shredded Pork (鱼香肉丝)

English translation: "Fish-Fragrant Shredded Pork"

What do you think this dish looks like?

"Take a moment — what do you picture on the plate?"

"It says 'fish-fragrant' — does it contain fish?"

"Is it a soup? A stir-fry? Something braised?"

"I'll just order kung pao chicken again and play it safe."

Sound familiar? You're not alone. Let's fix that.

LESSON 1

Cooking Methods = Texture

The cooking method tells you exactly what texture to expect before the food arrives.

Cooking Method	Chinese	Texture Outcome
Stir-fried	爆炒	Savory, quick wok toss, lightly charred
Braised	炖	Fall-apart tender, rich in liquid
Smoked	熏	Deep, earthy, smoky complexity
Steamed	蒸	Light, tender, clean natural taste
Qing-chao (Light)	清炒	Fresh, bright, crisp — minimal seasoning
Deep-fried	炸	Crispy golden outside, tender inside

Now let's see if you can apply what you've learned...

QUIZ — Round 1

What Is Hunan-style Stir-fried Beef?

Step 1: Use the cooking method vocabulary you just learned. Which description matches this dish?

A.

Tender beef slow-braised in dark soy and rock sugar until glossy and sweet.

B.

Beef cubes simmered in a numbing Sichuan peppercorn broth with chili oil.

C.

Sliced beef quickly tossed in a hot wok with smoky dried chilies, garlic and scallion — dry, fragrant, and pungently spicy.

D.

Sliced beef gently steamed with ginger and scallion, light and clear in flavor.

→ Click to reveal the answer!

What Does Hunan-style Stir-fried Beef Look Like?

"You said: 'Sliced beef quickly tossed in a hot wok with smoky dried chilies...' — now pick the image that fits."

A

B

✓ CORRECT

C

D

Correct Answers: Description = C, Image = C

Hunan style

Chili-garlic-smoky, dry not saucy. Direct heat from dried and fresh chilies.

Stir-fried

Fast wok-toss results in fragrant, slightly charred edges with no thick gravy or soup.

Together

A dry, intensely spicy plate. Eliminates saucy braises (A), numbing broths (B), and steamed items (D).

You decoded 'stir-fried' from Lesson 1 — but how did you know 'Hunan-style' means spicy? That's next.

Your Menu Decoding Journey

Stage 1 complete — Round 1 passed! Now for flavor words...

✓Stage 1: Methods — Stage 2: Flavor — Quiz — Final Reveal

✓ COMPLETE

Stage 1 — Cooking Methods = Texture

Learn how Chinese cooking techniques predict what your food will look and taste like. *You can predict texture from cooking methods!*

Stage 2 — Flavor & Style Words = Taste Preview

Decode regional styles and flavor signals hidden in dish names.

Quiz — Progressive Decoding + Scenario

Test your skills with real Chinese dish names. Round 1 partially complete!

Final Reveal — Decode the Mystery Dish

Put it all together on the dish from the opening slide.

Progress: ~35% — Moving to Stage 2!

LESSON 2

Flavor & Style Words = Taste Preview

These words in a dish name are a preview of what your taste buds will experience.

REGIONAL STYLE

Hunan-style (湘)

Intensely spicy, smoky, garlicky. Direct chili heat — no numbing. Dry and fragrant.

REGIONAL STYLE

Cantonese-style (粤)

Light, fresh, ingredient-forward. Minimal seasoning; clean and elegant.

FLAVOR SIGNAL

Mala / Numbing-Spicy (麻辣)

Ma (麻) = numbing from peppercorn + La (辣) = chili burn. Layered and electric.

FLAVOR SIGNAL

Yu-xiang / "Fish-Fragrant" (鱼香)

Contains NO fish. Sweet-sour-savory-spicy sauce (garlic, pickled chili, vinegar).

Hunan ≠ Mala

Hunan (湘) = pure chili heat — hits you straight, dry and smoky.

Mala (麻辣) = numbing + burning — two layered sensations.

Now let's test this with a very different dish...

QUIZ — Round 2

What Is Cantonese Steamed Fish?

Step 1: Use the flavor & style vocabulary you just learned. Which description matches this dish?

A.

Whole fish deep-fried until crispy, then drowned in a thick sweet-and-sour sauce.

B.

A whole fresh fish gently steamed with ginger and scallion, finished with hot oil and a light soy drizzle — clean, delicate, ingredient-forward.

C.

Fish fillet braised in a spicy bean paste sauce with numbing Sichuan peppercorns.

D.

Salted fish cured for weeks then pan-fried with garlic, intensely briny and pungent.

→ Click to reveal the answer!

What Does Cantonese Steamed Fish Look Like?

"You said: 'A whole fresh fish gently steamed with ginger and scallion...' — now pick the image."

A

✓ CORRECT

B

C

D

Correct Answers: Description = B, Image = B

Cantonese style

Light, fresh, ingredient-forward. The goal is to showcase natural flavor, not mask it with heavy spices.

Steamed

Gentle moist heat results in a delicate texture with no oil crust and no heavy, overpowering sauce.

Together

Clean, pale-colored fish with simple aromatics. Rules out deep-fried (A), spicy (C), and briny (D).

Your Menu Decoding Journey

Two stages done, two rounds passed! Almost there...

✓Stage 1: Methods — ✓Stage 2: Flavor — Quiz — Final Reveal

✓ COMPLETE

Stage 1 — Cooking Methods = Texture

Learn how Chinese cooking techniques predict what your food will look and taste like. *Texture prediction mastered!*

✓ COMPLETE

Stage 2 — Flavor & Style Words = Taste Preview

Decode regional styles and flavor signals hidden in dish names. *You can read flavor words like a pro!*

Quiz — Progressive Decoding + Scenario

Test your skills with real Chinese dish names. Rounds 1 & 2 done, Scenario next!

Final Reveal — Decode the Mystery Dish

Put it all together on the dish from the opening slide.

Progress: ~70% — Final challenge ahead!

Putting It All Together — Decoded!

Yu-Xiang Shredded Pork (鱼香肉丝) — "Fish-Fragrant Shredded Pork"

Flavor Word	Cooking Method	Main Ingredient
鱼香 (Yu-xiang) NOT fish — sweet-sour-savory-spicy sauce made with garlic, ginger, and pickled chilies.	**Stir-fried** Quick wok toss over high heat, ensuring the ingredients stay crisp and the sauce glazes perfectly.	**Shredded Pork (肉丝)** Thin pork strips combined with wood ear mushrooms and bamboo shoots for varied texture.

Overall Vibe

Complex (sweet + sour + savory + mild spice) — a glossy reddish-brown sauce clinging to shredded pork. **No fish anywhere.**

You decoded your first Chinese dish! One final challenge...

Scenario: Your Friend Cannot Eat Spicy Food

"Your friend cannot eat spicy food. You are ordering main courses together."

Which dish must they AVOID?

Cantonese Steamed Sea Bass	Hunan-style Stir-fried Beef	Stir-fried Seasonal Greens	Red-braised Pork Belly
$28	$24	$14	$22

SAFE **A) Cantonese Steamed Sea Bass:** Cantonese = light/fresh, Steamed = gentle. No chili used in this preparation.

AVOID **B) Hunan-style Stir-fried Beef:** Hunan prefix = chili-garlic-smoky, almost always spicy. Contains dried & fresh chilies.

SAFE **C) Stir-fried Seasonal Greens:** Qing-chao = "clear stir-fry": just oil, garlic, and salt. Crisp and not spicy.

SAFE **D) Red-braised Pork Belly:** Soy + rock sugar braise, sweet-savory. No chili involved in the slow-cooking process.

Your Menu Decoding Journey

Congratulations! You've mastered the Chinese menu!

✓Stage 1: Methods — ✓Stage 2: Flavor — ✓Quiz — ✓Final Reveal

✓ COMPLETE

Stage 1 — Methods

Mastered texture prediction from cooking techniques.

✓ COMPLETE

Stage 2 — Flavor

Decoded regional styles and flavor signals like a pro.

✓ COMPLETE

Quiz — Assessment

Successfully applied knowledge to real-world scenarios.

✓ COMPLETE

Final Reveal

Transformed the mystery dish into a decoded meal.

Score Summary

5 / 5 points

Perfect decoding accuracy across all quiz rounds.

Learning Achievement

Mastered the full decoding process: Dish Name → Style + Method → Predicted Flavor → Visual Recognition.

Future Application

Next time you sit down at a Chinese restaurant, decode the menu yourself. Enjoy your meal!

You are now a Chinese Menu Decoding Master.